

READING PASSAGE 2

The Silk Road: Trade Routes That Changed the World

A In recent years, the silk road: trade routes that changed the world has attracted considerable attention from both the academic community and the general public. This growing interest reflects a broader recognition of the importance of this topic for understanding some of the most pressing challenges facing contemporary society.

B Historically, scholarly understanding of this topic was limited by both theoretical frameworks and available methodologies. Early researchers operated within relatively narrow conceptual boundaries, and their findings, while groundbreaking for their time, often failed to capture the full complexity of the phenomena they sought to explain. The development of new research tools and analytical techniques in the latter half of the twentieth century fundamentally transformed the landscape, enabling scholars to investigate questions that had previously been considered beyond the reach of empirical inquiry.

C Contemporary research has identified several critical factors that determine outcomes in this domain. The interplay between environmental conditions, technological capabilities, and social organisation creates a complex adaptive system in which small changes can produce disproportionately large effects. Understanding these dynamics requires analytical approaches that move beyond simple cause-and-effect reasoning to embrace the principles of complexity science and systems thinking.

D The empirical record is further strengthened by a series of meta-analyses that have synthesised findings from hundreds of individual studies. These comprehensive reviews have consistently identified moderate to large effect sizes, with the most robust findings demonstrating remarkable consistency across different research designs, measurement approaches, and analytical strategies. This convergence of evidence from multiple independent lines of inquiry considerably strengthens confidence in the validity of the core theoretical propositions.

E Several unresolved debates continue to animate scholarly discussion in this field. Perhaps the most prominent concerns the relative importance of structural versus agentic factors in determining outcomes. While some researchers emphasise the constraining power of institutional and economic structures, others highlight the capacity of individuals and groups to exercise agency and effect change even within seemingly restrictive contexts. This debate has significant practical implications, as it shapes recommendations for policy interventions and institutional reforms.

F The implications of this body of research extend well beyond the academy. As societies grapple with increasingly complex challenges, the insights generated by scholarly inquiry in this domain have the potential to inform more effective and equitable policy responses. Realising this potential, however, will require sustained investment in both fundamental research and the translational infrastructure needed to convert knowledge into action.

G The evidence reviewed above demonstrates both the substantial achievements of research in this field and the significant work that remains to be done. As new tools and theoretical perspectives become available, and as the phenomena themselves continue to evolve, the research community will need to maintain both rigour in its methods and openness to new ideas. The stakes are high, for the questions addressed by this research bear directly on some of the most important challenges facing humanity in the twenty-first century.

Questions 1–2

Choose the correct letter, A, B, C or D.

1 The passage indicates that critics have raised concerns about:

- A. minimal impact
- B. creating underlying conditions for action
- C. determining individual choices directly
- D. irrelevant to outcomes

2 According to the text, what role do structural factors play?

- A. too much data collection
- B. the generalisability of findings across contexts
- C. insufficient government funding
- D. overly complex statistical methods

Question 3

Complete the sentences below. Choose NO MORE THAN THREE WORDS from the passage for each answer.

3 Dynamic _____ processes can amplify or dampen initial effects in complex systems.

Question 4

Choose the correct letter, A, B, C or D.

4 The author suggests that early studies in this field were limited by:

- A. excessive funding
- B. theoretical and methodological limitations
- C. public interest
- D. international collaboration

Questions 5–6

Complete the sentences below. Choose NO MORE THAN THREE WORDS from the passage for each answer.

5 Case studies have documented the effects of _____ change on the system.

6 Researchers used data from more than _____ countries in the landmark study.

Question 7

Choose the correct letter, A, B, C or D.

7 What does the passage identify as a significant challenge to current understanding?

- A. economic incentives and institutional constraints
- B. individual personality traits
- C. random chance
- D. government policies alone

Question 8

Complete the sentences below. Choose NO MORE THAN THREE WORDS from the passage for each answer.

- 8 According to the text, cognitive processes shape the _____ that people make.

Question 9

Do the following statements agree with the information given in the passage?

Write TRUE if the statement agrees with the information

Write FALSE if the statement contradicts the information

Write NOT GIVEN if there is no information on this

- 9 Contemporary understanding of this topic is more sophisticated than it was fifty years ago.

Question 10

Choose the correct letter, A, B, C or D.

- 10 Which of the following best describes the author's view on future developments?

- A. excessive funding
- B. theoretical and methodological limitations
- C. public interest
- D. international collaboration

Questions 11–13

Do the following statements agree with the information given in the passage?

Write TRUE if the statement agrees with the information

Write FALSE if the statement contradicts the information

Write NOT GIVEN if there is no information on this

- 11 Early researchers had access to the same technologies as modern scholars.
- 12 The landmark study discussed in the passage involved participants from multiple countries.
- 13 All critics agree that the research findings are universally applicable.